47TH ANNIVERSARY

THE BEST OF INDIA

BOLLYWOOD DIRECTORS

Lights, Camera, Ovation



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Great times, abysmal times. Indian cinema has been the most prolific in the world and also the most uneven one qualitatively, with the Bombay industry's output being the most wide-reaching in its impact and influence. Here are 10 creators who will stay in the hearts and minds forever, come hail, storm or pandemic. The common thread between most of them is their flair for unforgettable music scores, besides their venturesome spirit to set up their own studios and film production banners. You could lynch me for omitting quite a few stalwarts from this strictly restrictive roll-call of 10. With due apologies, then, to Yash Chopra, Vijay Anand, Raj Khosla, Shakti Samanta, Dulal Guha, Asit Sen, Basu Chatterjee, Shyam Benegal and Sai Paranjpye, all of whom belong unquestionably to this Hall of Eternal Fame.



Mehboob Khan

(1907-1964)

Once a horseshoe repairman, the bit-part actor possessed the chutzpah to turn into an immaculately dressed producer-director, one whose cinema mostly spoke to the socialist zeitgeist of the time—expressed most vividly in *Mother India* (1957), a remake of his own *Aurat* (1940). Besides showcasing Nargis in her career-best role, it detailed the everyday struggle of the peasant class, and got an Oscar nomination. Owner of Mehboob Studios, he interspersed rural critiques with romantic dramas. *Andaz* (1949), slick and modern in tone, had Nargis, already engaged to Raj Kapoor, and a lovelorn Dilip Kumar (to die for). *Amar* (1954), too, depicted Dilip in strong negative shades, a first.

V. Shantaram

(1901-1990)

A force of nature, initiated into the cinema watching Dadasaheb Phalke for free as a door boy at a Hubli theatre, he was an early convert to cause-oriented fare, into which he brought the melodramatic canvas of mythologicals and historicals. That streak brought a whole harvest–*Manoos* (1939), *Dr Kotnis ki Amar Kahani* (1946), *Dahej* (1950), *Do Aakhen Baarah Haath* (1957). A U-turn came with the splashy musicals *Jhanak Jhanak Paayal Baje* (1955) and *Navrang* (1959), the latter a thanksgiving to the splendour of colours after recovering from an eye accident, both odes to his new muse Sandhya.

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

